Sofa to Singletrack coach notes, for the MTB east crew to review

Date: 16 October 2026. These are the short messages the app shows riders after a check-in and at key moments. They were drafted alongside the signed-off plans but were not part of that sign-off. Please read each one and either tick it, change the words, or cross it out. Anything you change is what the app will say.

The signed-off session words (names, what to do, Done when) are not in this pack; they are unchanged.

1. Welcome message (adults)

Shown on the dashboard the day the plan is built

Welcome aboard, [rider's name]. Your first session, [first session], is a gentle one on purpose. No pressure, just get a feel for the bike.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

2. Check-in replies, weeks 1 to 3

Weeks 1 to 3. Deliberately unconditional: nothing about the plan changes, whatever the rider says.

Rider answered "Easier than expected"

Good sign. It means the base fitness is there. Don't jump ahead of the plan yet though; the next few weeks build for a reason. Just enjoy feeling strong and stick with what's coming next.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Rider answered "About right"

That's exactly where we want you in these first few weeks. Keep showing up at this effort and the fitness will build itself, nothing to change.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Rider answered "Tougher than expected"

Normal this early on: your body's adapting to something new. Don't chase the plan's pace if it doesn't feel right; slow it down, and it'll click over the next couple of sessions.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Rider answered "Had to stop early"

That happens. Plenty of people need a session or two to find their legs. Have a look at your bike setup (saddle height, tyre pressure) in case that's part of it, and go into the next one without expecting anything.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Rider answered "Didn't get to it"

Completely fine. The first few weeks are about building the habit, not hitting a perfect record. Just pick back up with the next one.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

3. Check-in replies, week 4 onwards

Week 4 onwards. The notes ask the rider to change their own effort; the app never changes the plan's minutes.

Rider answered "Easier than expected"

Nice. That's a sign to push a little harder next time out. Try holding a slightly higher effort on your next session and see how that feels.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Rider answered "About right"

That's the effort we want to see this deep into the plan. Keep it right there for your next session.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Rider answered "Tougher than expected"

Worth backing off slightly on your next session: ease the pace or shorten it a touch, and don't be afraid to walk sections that aren't clicking.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Rider answered "Had to stop early"

If that's happened more than once recently, it's worth taking your next session properly easy. Sometimes the body just needs a lighter week. One easier session won't undo your progress.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Rider answered "Didn't get to it"

No guilt needed. Life gets in the way. Just get back on for the next one whenever you can.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

4. Coach tips (the 'what riders worry about' section)

Nervous on descents

Look through the corner or the section ahead, not down at your front wheel. Where your eyes go, the bike tends to follow. Start slower than feels necessary; speed comes with confidence, not the other way round.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Aches and niggles

A bit of new-activity discomfort in the first couple of weeks isn't unusual, but anything sharp, one-sided, or that doesn't ease off deserves a proper check from a physio or GP rather than pushing through it.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Struggling on climbs

Everyone's got a different engine. The point is to ride your own pace and get to the top however long it takes. Sit slightly further back and keep pedalling smoothly rather than mashing the gear.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Missed sessions or lost motivation

This happens to everyone at some point. Don't try to catch up on missed sessions. Just get back on for the next one on the plan and let the momentum build again naturally.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

The bike feels wrong

Most early wobbles come down to saddle height (should let your leg almost straighten at the bottom of the pedal stroke) or tyre pressure (softer than road bikes, but not so soft it feels vague). Worth a quick check before assuming it's you.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Bad weather

Riding in the wet or wind is a genuinely useful skill to build, but if it's unsafe (ice, high winds, thunder), swap to the indoor/trainer option for that session rather than risk it.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Comparing yourself with other riders

Everyone on this plan started from a different point. The only comparison that matters is you against where you were a few weeks ago.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

5. Race week (adults)

Taper week

Feeling like you haven't done enough this week is completely normal. The whole point of a taper is doing less, so your legs are fresh. Trust the rest.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

The day before

Get your kit and bike sorted the night before so the morning is calm. Eat a meal you know agrees with you, and try to get a decent night's sleep. Nerves are normal and won't stop you riding well.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Race morning

Nerves before a first race are completely normal, even for people who've raced for years. Remember the goal today is finishing your own race, at your own pace. Enjoy it.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

6. Juniors: written to the grown-up

Sofa to Singletrack Juniors: every line here is written to the grown-up riding with the child, not to the child. These were not part of the signed-off coaching plans document; they are drafted for the MTB east crew to review and change before they are treated as final.

Welcome

Welcome, [rider's name]'s grown-up. The first game, [first session], is short on purpose: fifteen minutes, somewhere flat, and you count out loud. Helmet on before the bike moves, and stay within sight the whole time. When it is done, tick it here and [rider's name] collects the first badge.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

The grown-up answers for the child after each game. Nothing medical, nothing about pushing harder.

Grown-up answered "Loved it"

That is the whole plan working. Nothing to change: same place, next game, and let them tell someone about the badge.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Grown-up answered "Fine"

Fine is good. Fine means it was not scary and not boring. The next game adds one small thing, so keep the pace and the place the same.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Grown-up answered "Found it hard"

Play the same game again before moving on, somewhere flatter if you can, and stop while they are still enjoying it. The badge is for trying, not for perfect. If it was the standing or the braking that was hard, lower the saddle a touch.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Grown-up answered “Had to stop early”

Stopping early is fine and you made the right call. Next time out, halve the number of goes and finish with something they already like doing. A short, happy session beats a long one every time.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Grown-up answered “Didn’t get to it this week”

Nothing lost. The game is still there and so is the badge. Pick a day this week, keep it short, and do the same game rather than skipping ahead.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Race week

Race week for a Junior is a normal week with shorter games. Nothing new to learn now: a lap of the park, a whistle stop or two, and plenty of talking about what race day looks like, so nothing is a surprise.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

The day before

Bike checked together tonight, helmet and clothes laid out, a snack packed. Tell them the plan for the morning in order: park, sign on, look at the course, line up, ride, cake. Early night for everyone.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Race morning

Fun race means fun race. Get there with time to walk a bit of the course together, remind them where you will be standing, and that finishing is the whole job. Take the photo at the finish, not the start.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

Graduation

Sixteen games, sixteen badges, and a child who rides a trail standing up. A fun race is next if they want it, and the whole plan works again at the next age up: same games, bigger child, longer laps.

Crew: ☐ keep ☐ change ☐ drop

7. House style the notes were written to

Always: Keep it plain, practical and specific: real advice you'd say trackside, not generic hype. End on something forward-looking (the next session) instead of a pat on the back.

Avoid: No exclamation-mark enthusiasm, no fitness-app clichés ("crush it", "you've got this"), no medical claims.

8. Sign-off

Reviewed by: _____ Date: _____